Dude Zero One, Dude Zero Two, you're cleared hot.

Cleared hot.

They went streaking towards the target.

On my screen I watched the pilot's crosshair settle over the bunker.

One second.

Two.

White flash. Loud bang. The wall of the ops room shuddered. Dust and pieces of stone rained down from the ceiling.

I heard Dude Zero One's voice: *Delta Hotel* (direct hit). Stand by for BDA (battle damage assessment).

Plumes of smoke rose from the desert.

Moments later…just as I'd feared, Taliban came running out of the trench. I groaned at my Rover, then stomped outside.

The air was cold, the sky pulsing blue. I could hear Dude Zero One and Dude Zero Two way above, tailing off. I could hear the echo of their bombs. Then all was silent.

Not all of them got away, I consoled myself. Ten, at least, didn't make it out of that trench.

Still—a bigger bomb would've really done the trick.

Next time, I told myself. Next time, I'll trust my gut.

16.

I GOT PROMOTED, SORT OF. To a small lookout high above the battlefield. For quite some time the lookout had been driving the Taliban mad. We had it, they wanted it, and if they couldn't get it then they were bound to destroy it. They'd attacked the lookout scores of times in the months before I got there.

Hours after my arrival at the lookout, here they came again.